NHTSA Datasets and APIs

In Support of Open Government Directive

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NHTSA Datasets and APIs

Ratings

NHTSA's New Car Assessment Program conducts crash tests to determine how well a vehicle protects its occupants during a crash, and rollover resistance tests to determine the risk of a vehicle rolling over in a single-vehicle crash. Also, NCAP conducts advanced driver assistance system tests to determine how well the system avoids a crash.

Background

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Recalls

Manufacturers who determine that a product or piece of original equipment either has a safety defect, or is not in compliance with federal safety standards, are required to notify NHTSA within five business days. NHTSA requires that manufacturers file a defect and noncompliance report as well as quarterly recall status reports, in compliance with Federal Regulation 49 (the National Traffic and Motor Safety Act) Part 573, which identifies the requirements for safety recalls. NHTSA stores this information and the data can be used to search for recall information related to specific NHTSA campaigns and product types.

Metadata

Dataset Summary

Agency: **Department of Transportation**

Sub-Agency/Organization: **National Highway Traffic Safety Administration**

Category: 23, **Transportation**

Date Released: **December 16, 2002**

Time Period: **1949 to present**

Frequency: **Daily**

Dataset Information

Data.gov Data Category Type: **Raw data**

Specialized Data Category Designation: **Research**

Keywords: **Phone, Paper, Email**

Unique ID: **83**

Contributing Agency Information

Citation: N/A

Agency Program Page: https://www.nhtsa.gov/recalls

Agency Data Series: https://static.nhtsa.gov/odi/ffdd/rcl/FLAT_RCL_POST_2010.zip

Dataset Coverage

Unit of Analysis: **Vehicles, Tires, Child Safety Seats, Equipment**

Granularity: **United States**

Geographic Coverage: N/A

Data Description

Collection Mode: N/A

Data Collection Instrument: N/A

Data Dictionary/Variable List: https://static.nhtsa.gov/odi/ffdd/rcl/RCL.txt

Dataset Quality

Data Quality Certification: **Yes**

Privacy and Confidentiality: **Yes**

Applicable Information Quality Guideline Designation: **National Highway Traffic Safety Administration**

Additional Dataset Documentation

Technical Documentation: https://static.nhtsa.gov/odi/ffdd/rcl/Import_Instructions_Recalls.pdf

Additional Metadata: N/A

API

Approach A: Get by Model Year, Make, Model

Make the request to get the recalls for the required combination of Model Year, Make and Model.

- Syntax: api.nhtsa.gov/recalls/recallsByVehicle?make={MAKE}&model={MODEL}&modelYear={MODEL_YR}
- Example:https://api.nhtsa.gov/recalls/recallsByVehicle?make=acura&model=rdx&modelYear=2012

Response Fields: Response is a list of recalls for the given Model Year, Make and Model.

Working Sample: JSON

Approach B: Get by Model Year, Make, Model

Step 1: Get all Model Years

Request a list of available Model Years for a given product type (Vehicle).

- Syntax: api.nhtsa.gov/products/vehicle/modelYears?issueType=r
- Example: https://api.nhtsa.gov/products/vehicle/modelYears?issueType=r

Working Sample: JSON

Step 2: Get all Makes for the Model Year

Request a list of vehicle Makes by providing a specific vehicle Model Year.

- Syntax: api.nhtsa.gov/products/vehicles/makes?modelYear={year}&issueType=r
- Example: https://api.nhtsa.gov/products/vehicle/makes?modelYear=2021&issueType=r

Response Fields: Response is a list of vehicle Makes for that Model Year. Use the Model Year and a Make from this list to use in the next step.

Working Sample: JSON

Step 3: Get all Model for the Make and Model Year

Request a list of vehicle Models by providing the vehicle Model Year and Make.

- Syntax: api.nhtsa.gov/products/vehicle/models?modelYear={year}&make={make}&issueType=r
- Example: https://api.nhtsa.gov/products/vehicle/models?modelYear=2010&make=acura&issueType=r

Working Sample: JSON

Step 4 : Get all Recalls for the selected Model Year, Make, Model

Now that you have all three key pieces of information (Model Year, Make, Model), go ahead and make the request to get the recalls for the required combination.

- Syntax: api.nhtsa.gov/recalls/recallsByVehicle?make={MAKE}&model={MODEL}&modelYear={MODEL_YR}
- Example: https://api.nhtsa.gov/recalls/recallsByVehicle?make=acura&model=rdx&modelYear=2012

Response Fields: Response is a list of recalls for the given Model Year, Make and Model.

Working Sample: JSON

Approach C. Get by NHTSA Campaign Number

Get all recalls as part of a NHTSA recall campaign number

Request a list of recalls by providing the NHTSA recall campaign number

- Syntax: api.nhtsa.gov/recalls/campaignNumber?campaignNumber ={campaignNumber}
- Example: https://api.nhtsa.gov/recalls/campaignNumber?campaignNumber=12V176000

Response Fields: Response is a list of recalls for the specified NHTSA recall campaign number.

Working Sample: JSON

Notes

Color codes to understand each part of the request URL:

- Red: Method Name
- Green: Applicable parameters

Request parameters and method names are case sensitive

Data Dashboard

Download Data

Select the .zip file for the desired database to download and extract the data. See the corresponding.txt file for a description of the file layout. All times shown are Eastern Time (ET).

Path	Size	Updated
Import_Instructions_Recalls.pdf	1006 KB	10/27/2023 11:02:49 AM ET
FLAT_RCL_Annual_Rpts.zip	144 KB	04/15/2026 03:07:01 AM ET
FLAT_RCL_POST_2010.zip	14 MB	04/15/2026 03:07:01 AM ET
FLAT_RCL_PRE_2010.zip	7 MB	04/15/2026 03:07:01 AM ET
FLAT_RCL_Qrtly_Rpts.zip	1 MB	04/15/2026 03:07:01 AM ET
RCL.txt	3 KB	04/15/2026 03:07:01 AM ET
RCL_Annual_Rpts.txt	2 KB	04/15/2026 03:07:01 AM ET
RCL_FROM_2000_2004.zip	1 KB	04/15/2026 03:07:01 AM ET
RCL_FROM_2005_2009.zip	4 KB	04/15/2026 03:07:01 AM ET
RCL_FROM_2010_2014.zip	111 KB	04/15/2026 03:07:01 AM ET
RCL_FROM_2015_2019.zip	6 MB	04/15/2026 03:07:01 AM ET
RCL_FROM_2020_2024.zip	4 MB	04/15/2026 03:07:01 AM ET
RCL_FROM_2025_2025.zip	89 KB	04/15/2026 03:07:01 AM ET

Path	Size	Updated
RCL_FROM_2025_2026.zip	90 KB	04/15/2026 03:07:01 AM ET
RCL_Qtrly_Rpts.txt	1 KB	04/15/2026 03:07:01 AM ET
Recall_Communications.pdf	179 MB	04/29/2025 05:01:20 AM ET

You can also search recalls by date of when a recall was published, and filter by product type, on NHTSA.gov.

Investigations

After a preliminary review of consumer complaints and other information related to alleged defects, NHTSA obtains information from the manufacturer(including data on complaints, crashes, injuries, warranty claims, modifications, and part sales) and determines whether further analysis is warranted. If warranted, the investigator will conduct a more detailed and complete analysis of the character and scope of the alleged defect.

Download Data

Complaints

Complaint information entered into NHTSA’s Office of Defects Investigation vehicle owner's complaint database is used with other data sources to identify safety issues that warrant

investigation and to determine if a safety-related defect trend exists. Complaint information is also analyzed to monitor existing recalls for proper scope and adequacy.

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Manufacturer Communications

All manufacturers of motor vehicles or motor vehicle equipment, including low volume and child restraints, must submit to NHTSA copies of their manufacturer communications sent to dealers, distributors, owners, purchasers, lessors, or lessees regarding any defect, failure or malfunction beyond normal deterioration in use, failure of performance, flaw or other unintended deviation from design specifications whether it is safety-related or not.

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Car Seat Inspection Locator

Car crashes are a leading cause of death and injuries for children. Data show a high number of child car seats are not installed properly. Car seat inspection stations make it easier for

parents and caregivers to check to see if their car seat is installed correctly. NHTSA provides information to help people locate a car seat inspection station. Information for each station is reported to NHTSA and we attempt to validate the station locations using a commercial geographic database so that this data will, in most cases, be able to be used for driving directions.

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API